



took a steep dip after the faux pas over the hoax call from India threatening attack.

Mumbai attacks. The Pakistan Army has been under tremendous pressure after 9/11 with Musharraf making commitments to crack down on terror groups and go after the Al Qaeda. To keep the brass on board he claimed that the US had promised to put pressure on India to come out with an acceptable solution on Kashmir. He committed over 1,00,000 troops to defend its borders with Afghanistan. But then US demands kept mounting. First it was to deliver the Al Qaeda operatives. Then it was to go after the Taliban, followed by orders to 'get their leaders'. As pressure mounted to "deliver quality instead of just quantity" the credibility of Musharraf and the Pakistan's army took a beating. The army was seen as fighting America's war against fellow Islamists and internal unrest grew.

Musharraf compounded it by clinging to power and trying to muzzle the judiciary into compliance—a move that galvanised civil society against him. Musharraf had to go. So the presidency was distanced from the army with Kiyani taking over as the army chief in November 2007.

Meanwhile, to the army's growing concern, internal security had deteriorated with rebellions breaking out in Balochistan and North West Frontier Province. Extremist groups with the exception of the LeT were turning against the army and there were even attempts on Musharraf's life. Worse, Pakistan had its own Taliban to deal with. Suicide attacks and bomb blasts had become the norm. For the first time in the army's history, there were reports of desertions of some 900 of its personnel in the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) region. Morale was at an all-time low.

When he took over as chief, for a while Kiyani made the right noises that reassured the US and India. He wanted his generals to pull out of all political assignments and focus on the army's primary duty of defending the nation. As a political observer said, "It was a shrewd move because the army by then had become highly unpopular and some of its officers were openly corrupt." He then cleverly colluded with Zardari to oust Musharraf from the presidency.

Zardari, after taking over as President in September, began threatening the establishment by starting a whole new narrative on relations between India and Pakistan. He talked of not being burdened by the baggage of the

past and stated that "India was not a threat to Pakistan," even dreaming of a visa-free regime between the two countries. He expansively offered "a no first use" of nuclear weapons agreement to India that had the army brass gnashing its teeth. Pakistan's army doctrine in recent years rested on the premise that as long as India feared a nuclear first strike by Islamabad, it would not want to engage with its neighbour in a full-scale war. Both, the 1999 Kargil War and the 2001 Parliament attack had affirmed to Pakistan that India was chary of waging a full-fledged war with it. Zardari did a quick U-turn on his no first use offer after Kiyani reportedly ticked him off.

Kiyani, meanwhile, had begun asserting his independence. When the new government un-